Institution: Royal Ontario Museum
Registration Number: 919.5.17
Fabric: Attic earthenware
Shape: Plastic Oinochoe
Attribution: N/A
Date: Classical, c. ~350 BCE
Dimensions: H. 7.6cm; W. 5.8cm; D. 4.2cm
Provenance: Sigmund Samuel Collection

Fabric, Technique, Shape & Condition
Attic plastic oinochoe. A wheel-thrown vessel with a mould-made figural body and a trefoil mouth. The vessel integrates a functional jug form with a sculptural representation of Dionysus riding a panther.
The upper elements of the vessel (neck, spout and handle) are finished in black slip, while the figural body is covered in added white slip with traces of polychromy, most visibly on the grapes. The added colour is largely worn, while the black slip survives in a more stable condition on the upper components.
The vessel is small in scale and largely intact, with surface abrasion and loss of added pigment across the figural areas. No major structural losses are present.
Iconography The vessel takes the form of Dionysus seated frontally riding a walking panther (Fig. 1). The god is rendered with long hair falling to his shoulders and wears a chiton; he holds a bunch of grapes in his lowered right hand, the clustered rendered summarily relative to the more detailed figural modeling elsewhere. The panther walks in profile, with an elongated tail balancing the composition.
The grouping presents Dionysus in his dual aspect as a god of wine and a master of wild animals, with the panther functioning as both mount and divine attribute.

Fig. 1. Plastic oinochoe in the form of Dionysus riding a panther, Attic, c. 350 BCE. Royal Ontario Museum, Toronto. Accession no. 919.5.17. Image © Royal Ontario Museum.

Full figure plastic oinochoai are comparatively rare within the broader corpus of Attic plastic vessels, where head or bust forms predominate.[1] The decision to render Dionysus as a complete mounted figure rather than a bust reflects an ambition to adapt sculptural figural types into a ceramic medium structured by the formal 'anatomy' of the vessel, drawing on a widely attested iconographic tradition of Dionysus riding a panther in 4th century sculpture and small-scale terracottas (Figs. 2-3).[2]
As an oinochoe, the vessel functioned as a pouring device within the symposion, reinforcing its Dionysian imagery through use. It establishes a direct relationship between container, contents, and divine patron within the sympotic context, where Dionysian imagery reflects and frames the act of drinking.

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[1] Beazley, J. D. "Charinos." *The Journal of Hellenic Studies* (Cambridge, UK) 49, no. 1 (1929): 38–78. https://doi.org/10.2307/625001.

[2] Lissarrague, François. "IDENTITY AND OTHERNESS: THE CASE OF ATTIC HEAD VASES AND PLASTIC VASES." *Source (New York, N.Y.)* 15, no. 1 (1995): 4–9. https://doi.org/10.1086/sou.15.1.23205708.

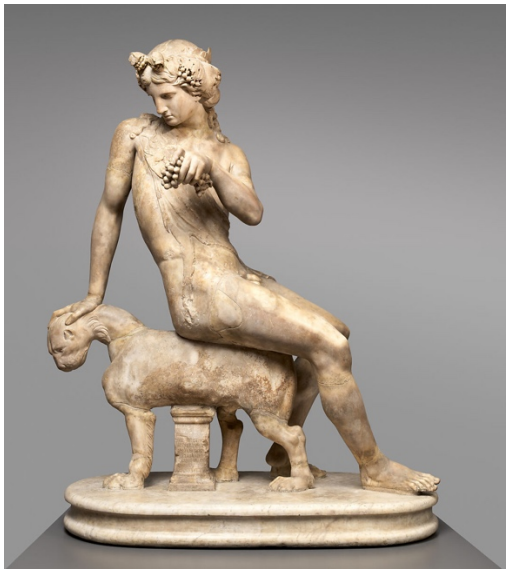

Fig. 2. Marble statue of Dionysos seated on a panther, Roman Imperial, 1st–3rd century CE, with later restorations attributed to François Duquesnoy. Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. Accession no. 03.12.7. Image © The Metropolitan Museum of Art.

Attribution No individual attribution is possible for this vessel. The combination of mould-made figural body and wheel-thrown functional components is characteristic of Attic plastic vessel production of the Classical period.[3] The iconographic type (Dionysus mounted on a panther, holding grapes) connects to sculptural prototypes developed in the 4th century BCE, consistent with the institution's attributed date of approximately 350 BCE. The fine modelling of the figural elements and the ambition of the full-figure format, unusual within the plastic oinochoe class, suggests a workshop of some skill operating within the broader Attic ceramic tradition of the Late Classical period.

Fig. 3. Detail of Dionysus riding a panther, Attic red-figure krater, c. 380–370 BCE. Musée du Louvre, Paris. Accession no. K 240. Image: Wikimedia Commons, public domain.

[3] Beazley, J. D. "Charinos." *The Journal of Hellenic Studies* (Cambridge, UK) 49, no. 1 (1929): 38–78. https://doi.org/10.2307/625001.

Works Cited

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